

PORTABLE MEDIA PLAYERS

PMPs have finally broken cover in India; and stepped boldly into the consumer space. Previously anyone who wanted a PMP went for a cellphone with music playback abilities and dumped the idea of a discrete gadget for music and movies. Convergence is a term we use all too frequently, even at *Digit*, but it bears remembering that there are no true substitutes for some devices. Just tell someone who has a good PMP from the likes of Apple, Cowon or Creative to switch to listening to music on his cellphone. Even if he has an N95, chances are he'll go "yuck".

PMPs have moved on from being just MP3 players to being a lot more multi-purpose. Many of them feature touch screens that are clear and crisp enough for a satisfying movie experience. You will also find a lot of other useful add-ons like a calculator, alarm clock, stopwatch, PIM (Personal Information Manager), contact book and so on. In fact many PMPs are full-fledged PDAs. Some like Apple's iPod Touch also have WiFi that allows you to access the Internet on the device via a built in browser. The most common feature is, of course, music and video playback and a few devices support multiple formats for both audio and video components. In short, PMPs are becoming all-in-one mobile entertainment stations.



BEST PERFORMER

Apple iPod Touch 8 / 16 GB

A lot of PMPs were excellent options and it was tough to choose a purist winner solely on the basis of performance. Most people still buy PMPs for their music abilities; after all you just cannot watch videos on your PMP on a crowded local or bus. Audiophiles demand the best; and Apple delivers. Whichever capacity you opt for, your ears are guaranteed a treat. Revealing, accurate highs;

to the point of being bright at times, they will serenade you. The mid-range is rich, with nary a hint of recession. The bass is clean, goes down low but is precise with no flabbiness whatsoever. Extreme bass heads may be a little disappointed; but we mentioned audiophiles, and flabby bass-boom has no place here.

Flash Based PMPs Up To Rs 10,000

REIGNING CHAMPION

Samsung T10

CHALLENGER(S)

Cowon D2

Cowon's D2 has been a sweetheart in our test labs this past year. It's very compact, and offers

unmatched features. The performance is right up there with the best of the PMPs and the touch interface adds a bit of pizzazz to an already attractive product. Our tests revealed its battery life to be a superb 37 hours while playing music; simply amazing. In terms of video quality the D2 has a superb albeit small screen that puts some of the larger screen based PMPs to shame. Music quality is superb; with just a hint of rounding off in the upper highs though to be honest this blemish won't even be noticeable to 99 per cent of users. The bass and mids are spot on, absolute tonal accuracy and the D2 is very suitable for audiophiles. It's available in two and four GB capacities, but thanks to the SD expansion you can get a lot more storage. Price reductions of the D2 now see it below the Rs 10,000 mark.

AND THE WINNER IS

Cowon D2

Cowon's intrepid D2 drops to under Rs 10,000 and ends up dominating proceedings in that category. If you're shopping for a PMP with strong video playback capabilities

and compactness is a factor then the D2 is the one for you. It's very feature rich and a very good performer as well and at a price of below Rs 10,000



Flash Based PMPs Above Rs 10,000

REIGNING CHAMPION

Apple iPod Touch 8 GB

Apple has really upped the ante with their iPod Touch series. The iPod Touch 8 GB is a beautiful piece of hardware. Apple's touch interface is beautiful, the finger swipe works flawlessly and is miles ahead of all the copy cats that spawned later; which makes you wonder why Touch clones even bother trying to duplicate Apples genius. The Touch is a full-fledged audio and video PMP and its 3.5-inch screen is crisp enough for a good portable movie experience. The audio component is excellent; the iPod Touch 8 GB is untouchable in terms of sound quality and while others like the Cowon D2 and Apples own Nano are nearly as good, there is a slight detailing in the highs which is absent from the others. The fact that its very compact and sleek just makes the Touch that much more appealing an option for nearly everyone who can spend more than Rs 10,000 on a PMP.

CHALLENGER(S)

Cowon Q2

AND THE WINNER IS

Apple iPod Touch 8 GB

Apple gets the glory here. Their Touch is a terrific performer that doesn't demand too much of in terms of price.

HDD-based PMPs

BEST BUY

Apple iPod Classic 5.5G 80 GB

Apple's iPod Classic 80 GB belongs to their 5.5 generation of HDD based PMPs. With a massive 80 gigabytes of storage you know you can cart around all your music with ease. It also plays video, courtesy the 2.5-inch screen that is bright and ultra clear. The fact that it's a great music player and provides a quality listening experience is just the icing on the cake.

CHALLENGER(S)

Apple iPod Classic 6G 120 GB, Cowon Q5W

Apples best gets a little better. Or rather bigger; the new iPod Classic sixth generation features a massive 120 GB of storage. The new iPod Classic 120 GB is largely the same device with a few minor changes in the firmware interface. The sound quality that Apple remains famous for is unchanged as are its video capabilities.

The Cowon Q5W is a device that needs little introduction. A huge five inch touchscreen, Windows Mobile 5.0, inbuilt Wi-Fi and Bluetooth, inbuilt loudspeaker and even a remote control unit makes the Q5W a premium PMP in any company. The screen is simply excellent, and the music playback is very good. For someone looking at a totally converged device with all the features the Cowon Q5W is worth looking at. The fact that it plays more video and audio formats than all the other players around itself speaks volumes for its achievements.

AND THE WINNER IS

Apple iPod Classic 120 GB

When it comes to sheer value nothing beats the performance coupled with the storage space of the iPod Classic 120 GB; especially not at a price of just Rs 13,000. Cowon's Q5W is a superb PMP; with far more capabilities than the iPod Classic; but at Rs 32,000 for the 80 GB model; its hard to justify paying so much for a PMP. Apple walks away with gold here; and deservedly so.

